



A FEMALE ROBINSON CRUSOE

By ARTHUR WOODWARD

ALLEXANDER SELKIRK had his DeFoe who made much over the short sojourn of the Scotsman on Juan Fernandez Island, but in reality Selkirk was but a transient Crusoe compared to the Indian woman who was abandoned, alone, on the bleak island of San Nicolas off the Southern California coast, for eighteen years.

About 1810 or 1811 Russian fur hunters cruised into the Southern California waters seeking new hunting grounds. The greatly prized sea otter then existed in great numbers in the foam churned seas that lashed the Santa Barbara Channel

Islands. Thither the Russians and their imported Aleutian Island hunters repaired, and slaughtered not only the fur bearing animals but the human inhabitants as well.

The tiny, fog bound island of San Nicolas, or Ghalas-at, as it was termed in the Chumash language, was the spot the savage northern raiders visited more often than any other. The numerous clashes took rapid toll of the simple islanders who were left after the mission padres had drafted numbers of them to work in the mainland missions at Santa Barbara, Ventura, Fernando and San Gabriel.

By 1835 the San Nicoleños were reduced to but a handful, and the mission authorities, seeking to save the lives of these pitiful few, sent a boat to the island to bring the remnant of the tribe off from their isolated homeland.

Now, it so happens that good landing places are few and far between on almost any of the Channel Islands and San Nicolas is one of the worst of the lot. Consequently the rescuers, working in a heavy sea, were under a severe handicap. However, in spite of the difficulties, they managed to get the last boatload on board when suddenly a woman screamed.

To the horror of the onlookers one of the islanders, a young matron, screamed fearfully and plunged overboard into the seething tide race and swam back to shore. It developed that in the confusion attending the packing and moving, the woman in question had forgotten her few months old baby, leaving it asleep in her rude hut.

Night was racing down from the mountains of the mainland, and the captain of the ship did not dare launch a small boat in such uncertain waters. So he put in for shore, leaving the woman and her child alone upon the island, intending to return within the week. The next day a terrific storm arose, and for many days it was impossible to get near the island.

The days mounted into weeks, the weeks into months, and the months into years. The woman was practically forgotten. It was argued that she was probably dead anyhow, and what was one Indian more or less?

The years drifted by and the Americans arrived to take over California. The newcomers hunted for sea otter and other marine animals in the channel waters. Gradually a story spread that San Nicolas was haunted. Hunters putting into the island for water spoke of seeing the wraithlike figure of a woman high up on the rocky headlands or running ghostlike along the beach in the moonlight. Then some one recalled the story of the lost woman.

Nearly eighteen years had passed since

the San Nicoleños had been removed and scattered among the missions. In that time the missions themselves had suffered reverses and were rapidly becoming historical landmarks. Surely the woman could not be alive. It must be her ghost the hunters had seen.

But there were a few hard heads who did not believe in ghosts. These men, residents of Santa Barbara, chartered a small vessel and put out to the island, intending to search it thoroughly. Within a few days they were rewarded with the sight of slender, naked footprints on a patch of sandy beach, tangible evidence that the Indian castaway was alive after eighteen years isolation.

Then one day they found her, crouched in her rude hut of whale ribs covered with rush matting, surrounded by her primitive tools and utensils of basketry and steatite. At first she was greatly terrified, but soon overcame her fear, and when the men told her, as best they might, in a rude sort of sign language that they had come to release her from her island bondage, the poor creature became quite animated.

She chattered excitedly, trying to tell them of her experiences, and by dint of signs she made them understand that her baby had died shortly after her abandonment. She had existed during the remainder of the years as her people had done before her, catching fish, killing birds and seals, making garments of their skins and tools of their bones. She took with her her robe of bird skins neatly sewed together with sinew, a patched basket or two, some bone awls and other primitive trinkets.

Upon the return of the boat to Santa Barbara with the female Robinson Crusoe every one tried to make the bewildered woman comfortable, but whether it was homesickness, age, or change of diet, in spite of all they could do for her she wasted away and died within a month or so after her release from exile. Some of her effects went to Rome, and the last traceable piece of her belongings perished in the San Francisco fire in 1906.